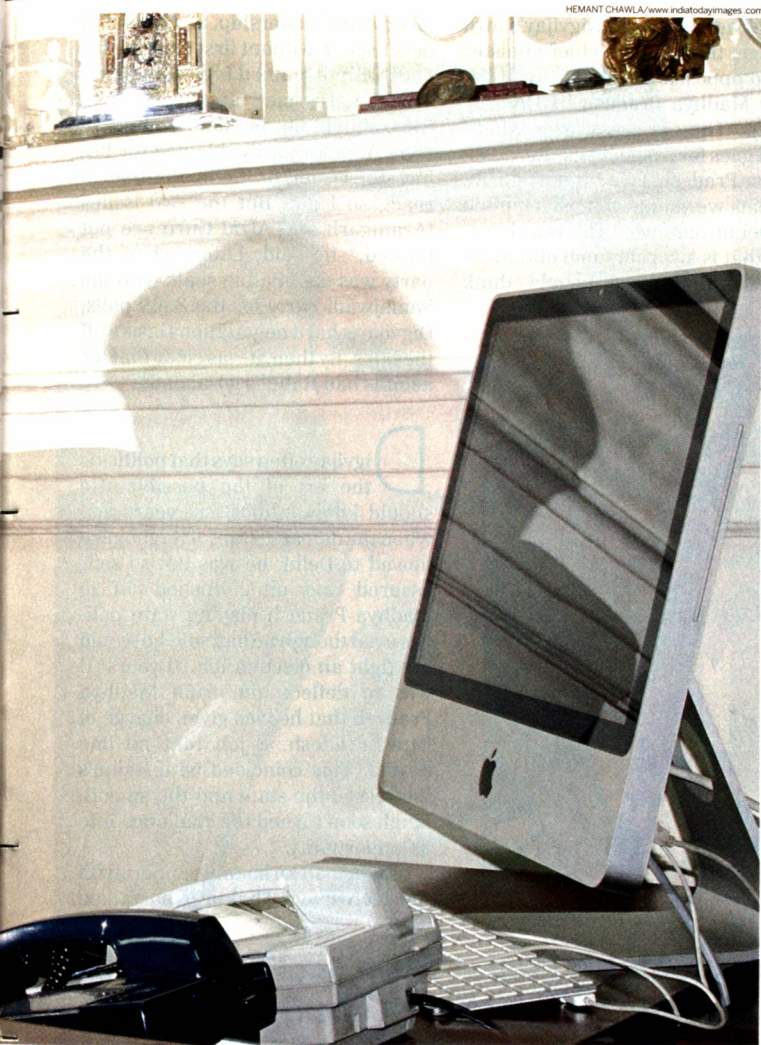




The Liberhan Commission took 17 years to tell us what we all knew. Instead, we should set up special fast track courts for such cases," says Digvijay. He claims there are about 25 families in Azamgarh whose members are accused in over 55 cases of terrorism. During his two-day visit to Sanjarpur village, he met the families of those accused of terrorism. He also raised doubts on the Batla House encounter saying, "I have seen photographs of the boys killed in the encounter. One of them had a bullet in his head. This does not seem normal."

Yet he insists that his visit was not limited to just the Batla House but that he had gone to see how Azamgarh, that was once a centre of learning, became "atankgarh", a terrorist hub. "The visit should not be seen as minority appeasement. All the accused come from lower middle class educated Muslim families. These boys, if innocent, could feel that they are not getting justice. This might lead to problems," he says. What he leaves unsaid is the impact that Mission Azamgarh would have on the 14 per cent Muslim vote in the state. And it is

GOING AGAINST THE GRAIN

"I've seen pictures of the boys killed. One has a bullet in his head. In encounters, one is not shot in the head."

Digvijay's comments about the Batla House encounter in Delhi have embarrassed the Congress.

"The Congress is not in the business of defending Afzal Guru or any other terrorist in the country."

In 2008 when the Congress spokesmen refused to take a clear stand, Digvijay stated the party line.

"Sharad Pawar should merge with Congress. The issue of Sonia's foreign origin on which NCP was formed is no more relevant."

When the Congress-NCP were negotiating seats for the Maharashtra polls, he suggested a merger instead.

"We are not standing before the SP with a begging bowl."

It was his hard bargaining that broke off the Congress-SP talks for an alliance during the 2009 polls.

no secret that the party's revival in Uttar Pradesh tops Rahul's agenda.

Despite Rahul's blessings, some Congressmen are worried that this blatant play of votebank politics could rebound on the party. Two years ago when a terror accused was caught from Sanjarpur village, former Uttar Pradesh Congress chief minister Ram Naresh Yadav had visited the village only to be pelted by stones. In the 2009 polls, BJP's Rama Kant Yadav won from here, cashing in on the Hindu-Muslim divide. The Rahul-Digvijay duo is hoping that their